Dvar Torah: Parshas Tetzaveh

Becoming the Mishkan: From Olive Oil to Living Garments

The Missing Name

Parshas Tetzaveh is unique in an unexpected way - Moshe Rabbeinu's name doesn't appear anywhere in it. From the moment Moshe enters the story in Sefer Shemos until now, he's been central to everything. And suddenly - silence.

Why?

Chazal connect this to a later moment in the Torah, when Hashem threatens to destroy the Jewish people after the Chet HaEgel. Moshe's response is immediate and powerful: "Mecheini na misifrecha" - erase me from Your book. I don't want to be the one person to take this forward. You brought me to lead a people, and I'm connected to those people. If they fall, I fall with them.

Moshe was **mevutal** - he nullified himself - to the klal, to Klal Yisrael as a whole.

We know that the words of a tzaddik always come true, even if the conditions aren't fully there. And that's what we see here in Tetzaveh. Moshe's name is wiped out from the parsha. His bittul is complete.

This is actually the perfect way to begin this parsha. Because before we can become a dwelling place for Hashem, before we can build the Mishkan within ourselves, we need to learn the middah of bittul. A Mishkan isn't built on ego - it's built on making space for something greater than ourselves.

Where Are We in the Journey?

Let's step back for a moment and see where Parshas Tetzaveh fits in the bigger picture of Sefer Shemos.

The sefer really has three movements:

First: Becoming a People. We experience slavery in Mitzrayim. Shared suffering forges our identity. The makkos teach us that Hashem controls every force in existence - false systems collapse, fear of the world is replaced with Yiras Hashem. We learn **who runs the world.**

Second: Revelation and Integration. Matan Torah. The Aseres HaDibros. Heaven and earth unite at Sinai. Then Mishpatim brings that holiness into daily life - middos are refined, there's no split between sacred and mundane. We learn **how a Jew lives in the world.**

Third: Building the Mishkan. "V'asu li Mikdash v'shachanti b'socham" - make Me a sanctuary and I will dwell **in them.** Not "in it" - in **them.** In us. This section teaches us structured construction, discipline, measurement, precision. We learn how to **build ourselves** as dwelling places for Hashem.

Parshas Terumah gave us the physical structure. Parshas Tetzaveh gives us something even deeper - it shows us how to build the **people** who will serve inside that structure. It shows us how **we** become the Mishkan.

Pure Oil: Refining Our Middos

The parsha opens with a beautiful image: "V'ata tetzaveh es Bnei Yisrael v'yikchu eilecha shemen zayis zach" - command the Children of Israel to bring you pure olive oil.

Shemen zayis zach - pure olive oil, with no sediment, no bitterness, no impurities.

How do you get pure oil? The Midrash and halachic sources teach us that the first and purest oil doesn't come from crushing or violent pressing. It flows naturally, almost oozing out on its own from the lightest touch.

Our middos are like olives. Love, anger, joy, jealousy, ambition, sadness, simcha - these are the raw forces inside us. The Orchos Tzadikim teaches that middos aren't meant to be destroyed or suppressed. They're meant to be **refined.**

Being **mitaken** on our middos doesn't mean beating ourselves up. It doesn't mean crushing ourselves or tearing ourselves down. It means learning to engage with our middos in a healthy way - allowing the pure oil to flow naturally, without violent pressure.

When I work on myself properly, I'm not destroying my anger - I'm refining it into appropriate boundaries. I'm not crushing my love - I'm channeling it toward kedusha. I'm not eliminating my ambition - I'm directing it toward growth in Torah and middos.

The Mishkan begins with light - the Menorah burning with this pure oil. And kedusha in our lives begins the same way: with **refined character.**

Precious Stones: Every Jew Matters

As we move through the parsha, we encounter the special garments of the Kohanim - the Eifod and the Choshen Mishpat. On the Choshen are twelve precious stones, each representing one of the shevatim.

What a beautiful message: **we are all precious jewels.**

Now, we're not talking about this in some inflated, ego-driven way. We're not the most expensive, painfully rare gems in the world. But we are precious. We are beautiful. Each shevet, each Jew, carried on the heart of the Kohen Gadol as he stood before Hashem.

You matter. Your unique contribution matters. Don't let it go to your head, but also don't diminish the beauty of who you are and what you bring to Klal Yisrael.

Clothing as Representation

The begadim - the garments - of the Kohanim teach us something profound about identity and representation.

In Chassidus, we learn that **machshavah, dibur, and maaseh** - our thoughts, speech, and actions - are called the **levushim** (garments) of the neshamah. The way we think, the way we speak, the things we do - these are the clothing that dress up the Jewish soul.

It's not that clothing makes the man. Rather, the man on the inside determines what the clothing represents. But here's the key: **clothing also has the power to channel who we represent.**

I was speaking with my mashpia one time about the minhag to wear special clothing on Shabbos - some people wear a long coat, a bekeshe. I asked him: where does this custom come from? What's the deeper mitzvah?

He told me something powerful. For him, the special clothing isn't just about honoring Shabbos (though that's certainly part of it). It's a **uniform.** It represents who he is, what philosophy he follows, what he stands for in the world.

Think about it: a soldier wears a uniform representing his nation. A police officer wears a uniform representing law and order. When someone acts properly while wearing that uniform, they bring kavod to what they represent.

The halacha even teaches that if a talmid chacham wears dirty clothing, it's a serious offense - there's a massive level of kavod at stake. Why? Because the clothing represents not just the individual, but the Torah they carry, the community they're part of, the Hashem they serve.

The Kohen Gadol on Yom Kippur

This becomes even clearer when we look at the avodah of Yom Kippur. When the Kohen Gadol enters the Kodesh HaKodashim - the Holy of Holies - he doesn't wear gold. His garments are simple, pure white linen. Nothing fancy. Nothing elaborate.

Why no gold? The Gemara explains: you don't want the prosecutor to become the defender. Gold reminds us of the Chet HaEgel, the Golden Calf. At the moment of our deepest teshuvah, we don't want that reminder.

But there's more. Those simple white garments represent **bittul.** The Kohen Gadol is representing all of Klal Yisrael - our collective nullification before Hashem, our return to purity, our essence stripped of all external decoration.

The garment expresses the identity. The garment channels the mission.

The Korban Tamid: The Power of Consistency

Then the parsha introduces us to the Korban Tamid - the daily offering, morning and evening, every single day.

This is where everything comes together.

The Gemara teaches: "Tadir v'she'eino tadir, tadir kodem" - that which is constant takes precedence over that which is occasional. Consistency defines who we are.

Every mentor, every teacher, every manager I've ever worked with says the same thing: **it's not the grand moments that define you. It's consistency.**

The Tamid isn't dramatic. There are no fireworks. It's just daily, faithful service. Morning and evening. Day after day.

How do you know a real friend from a fair-weather friend? The real friend is there day-to-day, consistently showing up in your life. The fair-weather friend only appears when things are exciting or when there's something in it for them.

Holiness works the same way. It's not built through occasional bursts of inspiration. It's built through **repetition, through daily practice, through showing up.**

If I want to be a Mishkan for Hashem, I need to ask myself: **What is my Tamid? What do I do every single day that expresses who I am and who I serve?**

The Ketores: Inner Fragrance

And then comes the Ketores - the incense.

Even a korban olah, which is entirely burned on the mizbei'ach, takes time to consume. But incense? It rises immediately and leaves no physical remnant behind. Only fragrance.

The Gemara teaches that **smell reaches the deepest levels of the soul.** The Ketores represents our inner refinement - the subtle, almost imperceptible impact of who we really are.

The oil represents refined middos. The Tamid represents consistent action. The Ketores represents **inner fragrance.**

Who are you when no one is watching? What impression do you leave when you walk out of a room? What scent lingers after you're gone?

Purim: Hidden and Revealed

As we approach Purim, there's a beautiful connection to make here. We have a minhag going back to the 1300s-1400s to dress up in costume on Purim. We turn everything upside down, inside out. The Maharil and Rama record this custom, and later thinkers connect it to the hidden realities of Purim - "v'nahafoch hu," everything flipped.

All year long, our garments represent responsibility, identity, mission. Our machshavah, dibur, and maaseh - our thoughts, speech, and actions - dress our neshamah with purpose.

But on Purim, we get to play. We get to be silly. We get to represent that which we usually keep in the deepest places. We loosen the structure a bit.

Why?

Because Purim itself is about hiddenness. Esther hides her identity. Hashem's name is hidden from the Megillah. The miracle is concealed within nature.

Purim reminds us that garments can **conceal** essence. Tetzaveh reminds us that garments can **channel** essence.

Both are true.

The question is: **What am I wearing all year long? What do my actions, my words, my thoughts say about who I really am and who I represent?**

Questions for Your Shabbos Table

As we head toward Shabbos and prepare for Purim, consider these reflections:

On Bittul:

- Where do I need to nullify myself to make space for Hashem?
- Where am I still holding on to ego in my avodah?

On Representation:

- What do my "garments" - my thoughts, speech, and actions - say about who I represent?
- If someone saw only my "uniform," what would they conclude about what I stand for?

On Consistency:

- What is my daily Tamid?
- Am I building my spiritual life on occasional inspiration or on steady, daily practice?

On Inner Fragrance:

- Is my inner avodah aligned with my outer identity?

Closing Thought

We left Mitzrayim and learned who runs the world. We stood at Sinai and learned how to live. Now, in these parshiyos about the Mishkan, we're learning how to **build ourselves** as dwelling places for the Shechinah.

Not through violence or crushing ourselves. Through refined middos like pure olive oil. Through garments of kavod that represent our mission. Through daily, consistent service like the Tamid. Through inner fragrance like the Ketores.

Parshas Tetzaveh teaches that holiness is worn, practiced, and repeated. Not dramatic. Not flashy. **Consistent. Measured. Real.**

"V'asu li Mikdash v'shachanti b'socham" - Make Me a sanctuary and I will dwell **in them.**

May we merit to become that dwelling place - not just in moments of inspiration, but in the quiet consistency of morning and evening, every single day.

Have an amazing Shabbos, and a freilichen Purim!

Gut Shabbos!